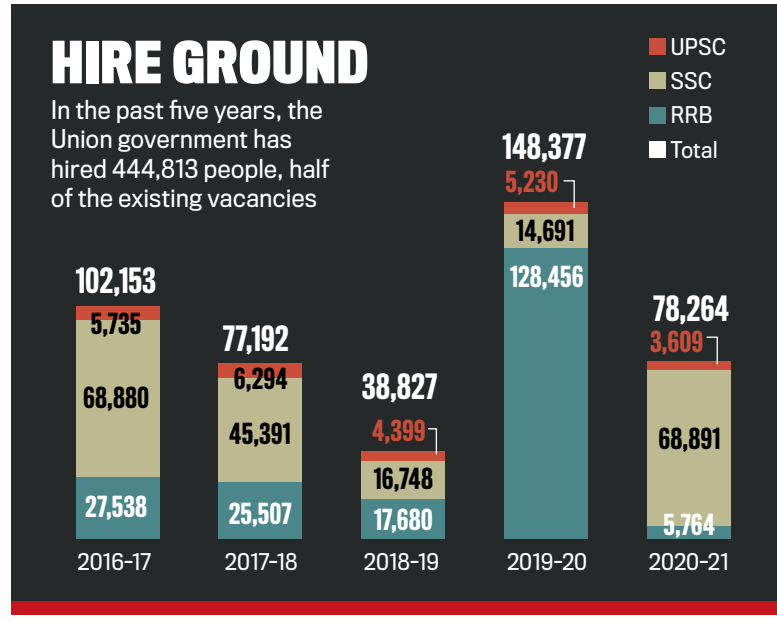


subsequent agitation by students, the state government cancelled the examination and conducted it again in January this year. "We have lost one year of our lives due to the government's mismanagement," says a dejected Ranjeet. He has little hope of things improving or transparency in the process. If he cannot clear it this year, he will give it one more shot. "After that, I will consider doing something else," he says.

34 MILLION*

Rough total of central and state government jobs

**Centre = 4 million. Figure for states highly unconfirmed.*



UP since 2013 are under the CBI radar—plunging the future of over half a million candidates into darkening shades of grey, with tragic repercussions. According to the Pratiyogi Chhatra Sangharsh Samiti, which represents the one million-strong floating contingent of students who prepare for competitive exams while being based out of Prayagraj/ Allahabad, over 50 candidates have committed suicide in the past two years. The city is headquarters to several major selection/ recruitment bodies in the state, and these often take "at least three to four years" to complete an exam process. "The age of the competing students keeps increasing and finally most of them spill out of the job race. The despair forces them to take drastic steps," says Prof. Roop Rekha Verma, former vice-chancellor of Lucknow University.

Scan the states, and you see that it's a systemic lag—ruling parties of all ideological persuasions perform the same. Mamata Banerjee's West Bengal has 200,000 vacancies, the BJP-ruled Madhya Pradesh has 100,000, and neighbouring Chhattisgarh, ruled by the Congress, has over 80,000. The BJP manifesto in 2018 had promised Madhya Pradesh 1 million jobs a year, including public and private sector. CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan recently floated a figure of 100,000 annually in the government sector alone. A rather ambitious target, considering it's higher than what the state could cumulatively achieve in the past five years—only 95,453 recruitments for class III jobs.

Social activist Akshay Hunka, who heads Berozgaar Sena ('The Army of Unemployed'), says government posts declined by three per cent between 2005 and 2020. "Governments usually don't recruit in the first two or three years of their term...they do so closer to elections. So vacancies keep getting added," he says.

Who'll do the job?

The numbers also tell a more dire story. Again, it's both a shock and not a shock to realise that most vacancies are in three departments which impact public life the most—health, education and police. The Rural Health Survey 2019-20 found that nearly 170,000 posts in the sector, including those of specialists, general practitioners, nurses, technicians and other paramedical staff, were lying vacant across India. Over 175,000 anganwadi workers and helpers, who provide basic nutrition and childcare services in rural India, are yet to be appointed.

A UNESCO report in October 2021 found that India had a shortage of over one million schoolteachers. And as per data compiled by the Bureau of Police Research & Development, there were 531,737 vacancies in police forces across India as of January 1, 2020, with UP (where 'law and order' recently became a winning election slogan) accounting for over 100,000 vacancies, highest among all states. Some states are seeking to make urgent amends. For instance, of the 100,000 recruitments Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa